WEIGHTED GRADES · STUDENT DRAFT FOR THE WORK GROUP

Weighted Grades: What Families Need to Know

A short explainer drafted by a student member of the SPASD weighted grades work group, October 2026. This is a recommendation. The School Board makes the final decision.

What's changing

Right now, SPASD uses an unweighted 4.0 GPA, so an A counts the same in every class. The work group is recommending a **5.0 scale for the most challenging classes**. In a weighted class, an A would count as 5.0 instead of 4.0.

Which classes would be weighted

Weighted (5.0 scale)	Not weighted
AP courses	College-credit or certification classes that match a class the high school already offers
Capstone classes, including try-out music courses	Classes that don't transfer for credit to UW colleges and universities
Classes that earn college credit or an industry certification	

Counselors are reviewing the Madison College class list now. Every weighted class will be marked in the course guide so students know before they choose.

Who it applies to

The recommendation is to start with **students entering 9th grade in fall 2027** (the Class of 2031) and add a grade each year after that.

Why not current students? Current high schoolers chose their classes under the old rules. Changing the rules partway through would reward some choices after the fact and not others, and it would change class rank for students who are already being ranked. Starting with a new class means every student in it knows the rules before choosing a single course.

Open question for the work group: 69% of caregivers of current high schoolers asked for it to apply now. One option to consider is weighting classes taken from 2027–28 onward for every student, without recalculating past grades.

Questions families asked

Does it apply to my student? Under the recommendation, only to students starting 9th grade in fall 2027 or later.

Will past grades be recalculated? No. Grades already earned stay as they are.

How does it connect to Act 95 and college? Act 95 guarantees admission to Universities of Wisconsin schools for students in the top 10% of their class (top 5% for UW–Madison), so class rank matters. Many colleges also recalculate GPAs their own way. *[District to confirm how weighted GPA will be used for class rank and shown on transcripts.]*

Is it fair to students who can't take AP? Weighted classes have to be open to every student who meets the prerequisites. *[District to add how students get support to access these classes.]*

How can I give input? The plan goes to the Board's Teaching & Learning Committee on **November 2** (4:45 PM, District Service Center) and the full Board on **November 9**. Both meetings are open to the public.

Based on the work group's October 15 and 20 recommendations and the caregiver survey (531 responses, October 16–22, 2026). Items in brackets need district confirmation before this is shared with families. Spanish version to follow.